GL91 - Engagement Across Semester

From Maple Groves to Redwood Canopies

Minerva University

GL91 Global Learning

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November 21, 2024



SELF-DIRECTED - MUIR WOODS

The idea for the camping trip to Muir Woods came to me one afternoon when I was sitting in my dorm, scrolling through photos of my time at Pearson College in Canada. I had spent years surrounded by dense forests, hiking through backcountry trails, and building boardwalks to protect old-growth trees. Nature had been my constant companion, and the silence of the forest had been my refuge. But since moving to the city, I felt a growing distance from that side of me—the outdoorsy, adventure-seeking Canadian girl who lived for the depths of the woods. While I love the city, I needed to reconnect, and that's when I decided to organize the trip for fall break.

I invited a group of friends, all of whom had never really gone camping before. I was eager to show them another side of me—the one who thrived in nature, who could build a fire with a few sticks and set up a tent in the dark. I wanted them to experience the peace that comes from being surrounded by towering trees, the sense of adventure that comes with hiking, and the simplicity of cooking oatmeal over an open flame. I hoped it would be a chance for all of us to

step away from the chaos of city life and immerse ourselves in something that felt much more grounded.

When we arrived in Muir Woods, it felt like stepping into another world. The towering redwoods, the soft crunch of fallen leaves beneath our feet, the smell of damp earth and moss—it was all so familiar, yet it felt like I hadn't experienced it in years. As we hiked deeper into the forest, I couldn't help but feel a rush of nostalgia. This was the kind of place where I had spent so many weekends back in Canada, building boardwalks in rain or shine, hoping to protect the ancient forests. On the first day, we hiked to a nearby beach, following trails that wove through lush ferns and beneath the towering canopy. As I led the way, I shared stories of summiting mountains and exploring thousand-year-old forests in Canada, my friends hanging on every word. Yet, what stayed with me most wasn't their fascination with my tales but the wonder in their eyes—the unmistakable spark of experiencing the magic of forests first hand.

As we settled around the campfire that night, I reflected on how much I had missed this part of myself—the side that wasn't defined by schoolwork or city life, but by the simple joys of being in nature. Sharing that with my friends, seeing them experience it for the first time, felt like a gift. I realized that not only had I been reconnecting with nature, but I had also been reconnecting with a part of me that I had forgotten. The forest, the trees, the trails—it all reminded me of the importance of protecting these spaces, of doing the work to preserve what is still wild and untouched.

WORD COUNT: 498 WORDS

AI STATEMENT

AI usage was minimal in this process. I used tools like Grammarly and Google Spell Check for basic grammar and spelling corrections.

For the reflection, I chose to use this opportunity to dig deep into a profound and meaningful experience, writing a personal narrative to capture my thoughts and emotions authentically.